

1 Universal Bundles and Characteristic Classes

This section will lay the groundwork for the subsequent material, by recalling the notions of principal bundles, universal bundles and characteristic classes. We assume the reader to be familiar with the concept of a fiber bundle with structure group. A classical reference for this is for example [?].

1.1 Principal Bundles and Associated Bundles

Definition 1.1. Let G be a topological group. A G -principal bundle is a fiber bundle with fiber G and structure group G acting by left translations.

The total space of a G -principal bundle $P \xrightarrow{\pi} B$ carries a natural right action of G defined as follows. Around $y \in P$ choose a local trivialisation

$$\phi: U \times G \rightarrow \pi^{-1}(U)$$

and let $\phi^{-1}(y) = (\pi(y), h)$. Then set

$$y \cdot g := \phi(\pi(y), hg).$$

This is well defined since by definition G acts on itself by *left* translations under a change of local trivialisation. A morphism of principal bundles should respect this right action, thus we define:

Definition 1.2. A morphism from a G -principal bundle $P \rightarrow B$ to a G -principal bundle $P' \rightarrow B'$ is a pair (F, f) of continuous maps $F: P \rightarrow P'$ and $f: B \rightarrow B'$, such that

$$\begin{array}{ccc} P & \xrightarrow{F} & P' \\ \downarrow & & \downarrow \\ B & \xrightarrow{f} & B' \end{array}$$

commutes and such that F is equivariant, that is $F(x \cdot g) = F(x) \cdot g$ for all $x \in P$ and $g \in G$. If $B = B'$ we assume f to be the identity.

The condition of equivariance in the above definition is actually quite strong as illustrated by the following proposition.

Proposition 1.3. *Any morphism of G -principal bundles over the same base space is an isomorphism.*

Proof. First suppose we are given a morphism

$$F: B \times G \rightarrow B \times G$$

of trivial bundles. Then by definition F is of the form

$$F(x, g) = (x, \phi_x(g))$$

for a continuous family of equivariant maps $\phi_x: G \rightarrow G$. By equivariance $\phi_x(g) = \phi_x(e)g$ and thus an inverse of F is given by

$$F^{-1}(x, g) := (x, \phi_x(e)^{-1}g).$$

Since every G -principal bundle is locally trivial this shows that we can always find local inverses in the general case and since inverses are unique they fit together to define a global inverse. $\square$

ÜBERLEITUNG!! Let $p: E \rightarrow B$ be a fiber bundle with fiber F and structure group G and let F' be another space upon which G acts effectively. Then we can construct a new bundle as follows. Choose an open cover $(U_\alpha)_{\alpha \in A}$ of B together with local trivialisations $\phi_\alpha: U_\alpha \times F \rightarrow p^{-1}(U_\alpha)$. Then there are transition functions $\tau_{\alpha\beta}: U_\alpha \cap U_\beta \rightarrow G$ defined by

$$(\phi_\beta^{-1} \circ \phi_\alpha)(x, f) = (x, \tau_{\alpha\beta}(x) \cdot f).$$

Define

$$E' := \left(\coprod_{\alpha \in A} U_\alpha \times F' \right) / \sim$$

where the equivalence relation $\sim$ is defined by

$$(b, f', \beta) \sim (b, \tau_{\alpha, \beta}(b) \cdot f', \alpha)$$

and let $p': E' \rightarrow B$, $[(b, f', \alpha)] \mapsto b$. It is then not too hard to show, that $p': E' \rightarrow B$ can be given the structure of a fiber bundle with fiber F' and structure group G with the same transition functions $\tau_{\alpha\beta}$ (QUELLE). We say that this new bundle is obtained from $E \rightarrow B$ by *changing the fiber* from F to F' (with the G -action on F' be implicit). Note that we can obtain $E \rightarrow B$ back from $E' \rightarrow B$ by changing the fiber from F' back to F . Thus no information is lost in this process. Considering the special case $F' = G$ with G acting on itself by left translations, we call the bundle obtained from $E \rightarrow B$ by changing the fiber from F to G the *associated principal bundle*. Morally speaking if we want to understand the bundle $E \rightarrow B$ it is sufficient to understand its associated principal bundle, as it contains the same information as we have seen above. The benefit of studying principal bundles is that they are very symmetric objects, making them easier to understand. For example many constructions simplify when performed on principal bundles, such as the ... of universal bundles as we will see in the next subsection. Another such instance is the construction of changing the fiber from above, which can be made more directly in the case of principal bundles. This is known as the *Borel Construction*:

Lemma 1.4 (Borel Construction, QUELLE?). *Let $P \xrightarrow{p} B$ be a G -principal bundle and F a space upon which G acts effectively from the left. Then*

$$E := (P \times F) / \sim, \quad (y, f) \sim (y \cdot g, g^{-1}f)$$

together with the map $\pi: E \rightarrow B$ given by $[(y, f)] \mapsto p(y)$ is a fiber bundle with fiber F and structure group G . Moreover this bundle is isomorphic to the bundle obtained from $P \rightarrow B$ by changing the fiber from G to F using the construction outlined above.

The Borel construction is the reason why the bundle obtained from $P \rightarrow B$ by changing the fiber from G to F is usually denoted by $P \times_G F \rightarrow B$. With this notation in mind we can formulate an important naturality property regarding the change of fibers.

Lemma 1.5. *Let $P \rightarrow B$ be a G -principal bundle, F a space upon which G acts effectively and $f: B' \rightarrow B$ a continuous map. Then*

$$(f^*P) \times_G F \cong f^*(P \times_G F).$$

Proof. (Using the explicit description of $P \times_G F$ from Lemma 1.4 this should be relatively straightforward) $\square$

Lets look at some concrete examples for the theory developed above.

Example 1.6. For simplicity we assume all base spaces B to be smooth manifolds in this example.

- i) Let $E \rightarrow B$ be a real rank n vector bundle. Choosing a bundle metric gives $E \rightarrow B$ the structure of a fiber bundle with fiber $\mathbb{R}^n$ and structure group $O(n)$. The associated principal bundle is explicitly given by the *orthonormal frame bundle* of E , whose fiber over a point $x \in B$ is the space of all ordered bases of E_x .
- ii) An orientation of a real vector bundle allows us to further reduce the structure group to $SO(n)$. The associated principal bundle is then given by the *oriented orthonormal frame bundle* of E , whose fiber over a point $x \in B$ is the space of all oriented ordered bases of E_x .
- iii) An example, which will be of relevance later is the following. Let $P \rightarrow B$ be an S^1 -principal bundle. We can change the fiber of P from S^1 to D^2 to obtain another bundle $E \rightarrow B$, where S^1 acts on D^2 by rotations. Since this action just extends the action of $S^1 = \partial D^2$ on itself we see that $P \cong \partial E$. So in particular the total space of any S^1 -principal bundle is null-bordant.
- iv) The associated principal bundle of the tautological line bundle $\xi_1^n \rightarrow \mathbb{C}P^n$ is given by the projection map $S^{2n+1} \rightarrow \mathbb{C}P^n$ dividing out the S^1 action on S^{2n+1} . PROOF

1.2 Universal Bundles and Classifying Spaces

A natural question is how many bundles exist... again easier for principal bundles... For simplicity we assume all base spaces to be CW-complexes in this section.

Definition 1.7. A G -principal bundle $E \rightarrow B$ is called universal if E is weakly contractible as a topological space.

The significance of this definition is established by the following theorem. We say that two morphisms of G -principal bundles are G -homotopic if they are homotopic through morphisms of G -principal bundles.

Theorem 1.8. *Let $E \rightarrow B$ be a universal G -principal bundle. Then for any other G -principal bundle $P \rightarrow X$ there exists a morphism $P \rightarrow E$ of G -principal bundles, which is unique up to G -homotopy.*

Before showing the Theorem let us discuss its implications. Firstly we can equivalently formulate the Theorem by saying that $E \rightarrow B$ is a terminal object in the homotopy category of G -principal bundles over CW-complexes and thus in particular uniquely determined (up to G -homotopy equivalence). This justifies writing $EG := E$ and $BG := B$. Since any bundle morphism $(F, f): P \rightarrow EG$ induces a morphism $P \rightarrow f^*EG$ (and vice versa, which is true for arbitrary fiber bundles) we moreover conclude from Proposition 1.3 that

$$P \cong f^*EG.$$

We call f a **classifying map** for P . By homotopy invariance of the pullback we get a well-defined bijection

$$\phi_X: [X, BG] \rightarrow \mathcal{P}_G(X), [f] \mapsto [f^*EG],$$

where $\mathcal{P}_G(X)$ denotes the set of isomorphism classes of G -principal bundles over X . To see that ϕ_X is indeed bijective note that the existence result in Theorem ?? shows that ϕ_X is surjective and the uniqueness result shows that it is injective. Moreover ϕ_X is clearly natural in X . Thus we have shown.

Corollary 1.9. *The maps ϕ_X define a natural isomorphism of contravariant functors*

$$[-, BG], \mathcal{P}_G(-): \mathbf{HCW} \rightarrow \mathbf{Set},$$

where $\mathbf{HCW}$ denotes the homotopy category of CW-complexes.

Theorem 1.8 will be an application of the following Theorem.

Theorem 1.10. *Let $P \rightarrow X$ be a G -principal bundle and $A \subseteq X$ a subcomplex. Then any morphism $P|_A \rightarrow EG$ can be extended to a morphism $P \rightarrow EG$.*

A proof of this Theorem based on an inductive cell by cell approach can be found in [?, Theorem 2.7.1].

Proof of Theorem 1.8. Applying Theorem 1.10 to $A = \emptyset$ shows the existence of a morphism $P \rightarrow EG$. Now suppose we are given morphisms $F_0, F_1: P \rightarrow EG$. Consider the G -principal bundle

$$\pi \times \text{id}: P \times [0, 1] \rightarrow X \times [0, 1],$$

where $\pi: P \rightarrow X$ is the bundle projection (this is just the pullback bundle of P under the projection $X \times [0, 1] \rightarrow X$). Then F_0 and F_1 define a morphism of G -principal bundles

$$(F_0, F_1): P \times \{0, 1\} = (P \times [0, 1])|_{X \times \{0, 1\}} \rightarrow EG,$$

which by Theorem 1.10 can be extended to $P \times [0, 1]$, thus yielding a G -homotopy between F_0 and F_1 . $\square$

of course for this theory to be of any use we need such universal bundles to exist...

Theorem 1.11 (Milnor construction). *For any topological group G there exists a universal G -principal bundle $EG \rightarrow BG$, where BG is a CW-complex.*

understood principal bundles, how can we recover information about general bundles – i.e. changing the fiber

Corollary 1.12. *Let G be a topological group acting effectively on a space F . Then for any CW -complex X the map*

$$[X, BG] \rightarrow \mathcal{F}_{F,G}(X), \quad [f] \mapsto [f^*(EG \times_G F)]$$

is a natural bijection, where $\mathcal{F}_{F,G}(X)$ denotes the set of isomorphism classes of fiber bundles with fiber F and structure group G over X .

Proof. By 1.9 the map

$$[X, BG] \rightarrow \mathcal{P}_G(X), \quad [f] \mapsto [f^*EG]$$

is a natural bijection and by Lemma 1.5

$$\mathcal{P}_G(X) \rightarrow \mathcal{F}_{F,G}(X), \quad [P] \mapsto [P \times_G F]$$

is a natural bijection. Composing both thus yields the natural bijection

$$[X, BG] \rightarrow \mathcal{F}_{F,G}(X), \quad [f] \mapsto [(f^*EG) \times_G F].$$

So the statement follows by again applying Lemma 1.5. □

Let us look at some examples...

Example 1.13. label

- *) $BO(n)$ and $EO(n)$ explicit via Stiefel Manifolds (compare n lab) + $EO(n) \times_{O(n)} \mathbb{R}^n \cong \xi_n^\infty$ for ξ_n^∞ tautological bundle over grassmanian
- *) Analogous for complex case??
- *) Special cases $\mathbb{R}P^\infty$ and $\mathbb{C}P^\infty$
- *) $M \rightarrow B\pi_1(M)$ induces iso on π_1

1.3 Stiefel-Whitney and Chern-Classes

We have seen how Another fundamental question is of course how to decide, whether two bundles are isomorphic. As usual in topology, one tries to define certain invariants posing as an obstruction... For vector bundles (or more generally principal bundles), ... characteristic classes. The general definition of a characteristic class is as follows. Let $\mathbb{K} = \mathbb{R}, \mathbb{C}$ and write $\text{Vect}_{\mathbb{K}}(B)$ for the set of isomorphism classes of $\mathbb{K}$ -vector bundles over a space X . Then $\text{Vect}_{\mathbb{K}}(-)$ defines a contravariant functor $\text{Top} \rightarrow \text{Set}$. A characteristic class c for $\mathbb{K}$ -vector bundles with values in the cohomology theory H^* is a natural transformation from the functor $\text{Vect}_{\mathbb{K}}(-)$ to the functor H^* regarded as a functor with values in Set . So in more concrete terms c assigns to each $\mathbb{K}$ -vector bundle $E \rightarrow B$ a cohomology class $c(E) \in H^*(B)$ depending only on the isomorphism class of E , such that for any continuous map $f: B' \rightarrow B$ the following naturality condition holds

$$c(f^*E) = f^*c(E).$$

So in particular, using the theory of classifying spaces developed above, we see that for a real (resp. complex) rank k vector bundle $E \rightarrow B$, the class $c(E)$ is uniquely determined by the value $c(\xi_k^\infty) \in H^*(BO(k))$ for the universal bundle ξ_k^∞ introduced in example...

For real vector bundles the most important characteristic classes are the so called *Stiefel-Whitney classes*, which can be completely characterized by a few axioms.

Definition 1.14 (Stiefel-Whitney Classes, HATCHER). There is a unique sequence of characteristic classes $w_1, w_2, \dots$ for real vector bundles with values in $H^*(-; \mathbb{Z}_2)$, such that

- i) $w_i(E) \in H^i(B; \mathbb{Z}_2)$ for any real bundle $E \rightarrow B$,
- ii) $w_i(E) = 0$ for $i > \text{rank}(E)$,

iii) $w(E_1 \oplus E_2) = w(E_1) \smile w(E_2)$, where $w = 1 + w_1 + w_2 + \dots$,

iv) For the canonical line bundle $\xi_1^\infty \rightarrow \mathbb{R}P^\infty$, $w_1(E)$ is the generator of $H^1(\mathbb{R}P^\infty; \mathbb{Z}_2) \cong \mathbb{Z}_2$.

Note that by property ii) the sum $w = 1 + w_1 + w_2 + \dots$ is always finite. This class $w(E)$ is called the *total Stiefel-Whitney class* of E . For obvious reasons one sometimes writes $w_0(E) := 1 \in H^0(B; \mathbb{Z}_2)$. The analogues for complex vector bundles are known as *Chern classes*.

Definition 1.15 (Chern Classes, HATCHER). There is a unique sequence of characteristic classes $c_1, c_2, \dots$ for complex vector bundles with values in $H^*(-; \mathbb{Z})$, such that

- i) $c_i(E) \in H^{2i}(B; \mathbb{Z})$ for any complex bundle $E \rightarrow B$,
- ii) $c_i(E) = 0$ for $i > \text{rank}(E)$,
- iii) $c(E_1 \oplus E_2) = c(E_1) \smile c(E_2)$, where $c = 1 + c_1 + c_2 + \dots$,
- iv) For the canonical line bundle $\tau_1^\infty \rightarrow \mathbb{C}P^\infty$, $c_1(E)$ is a generator of $H^2(\mathbb{C}P^\infty; \mathbb{Z}) \cong \mathbb{Z}$ specified in advance.

Again $c = 1 + c_1 + c_2 + \dots$ is well-defined and is called the *total Chern class*. Again one sometimes writes $c_0(E) := 1 \in H^0(B; \mathbb{Z})$. See [HATCHER] for a proof of existence and uniqueness.

Example 1.16.

- i) Let $\iota: \mathbb{R}P^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}P^\infty$ be the canonical inclusion. Then the pullback $\iota^*\xi_1^\infty \cong \xi_1^n$ is the tautological line bundle $\xi_1^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}P^n$. Since ι induces an isomorphism on cohomology we conclude from naturality that $w_1(\xi_1^n) = \iota^*w_1(\xi_1^\infty)$ is the generator of $H^1(\mathbb{R}P^n; \mathbb{Z}_2) \cong \mathbb{Z}_2$. Similarly $c_1(\tau_1^n)$ of the tautological complex line bundle $\tau_1^n \rightarrow \mathbb{C}P^n$ is a generator of $H^2(\mathbb{C}P^n; \mathbb{Z}) \cong \mathbb{Z}$.
- ii) Let $\varepsilon \rightarrow B$ be a trivial real bundle over some space B . Then $\varepsilon \cong f^*\varepsilon$ for a constant map $f: B \rightarrow B$ and thus $w_i(\varepsilon_n) = f^*w_i(\varepsilon) = 0$ for all $i \geq 1$. Similarly all Chern classes for complex trivial bundles vanish.
- iii) Let $TS^n \rightarrow S^n$ be the tangent bundle of the sphere and let $\nu_n \rightarrow S^n$ be the normal bundle. Since ν_n and $TS^n \oplus \nu_n$ are trivial we conclude from the example above and property iii) in Definition 1.14 that

$$1 = w(TS^n \oplus \nu_n) = w(TS^n) \smile w(\nu_n) = w(TS^n) \smile 1 = w(TS^n).$$

Thus $w_i(TS^n) = 0$ for all $i \geq 1$.

In the last example we have seen that although all Stiefel-Whitney classes of a bundle vanish, the bundle need not be trivial. However for one-dimensional real (resp. complex) bundles it turns out that they are already completely classified by their first Stiefel-Whitney class (resp. Chern class):

Theorem 1.17 (Hatcher, Proposition 3.10). *Let X be a CW-complex. Then the maps*

$$w_1: \text{Vect}_{\mathbb{R}}(X) \rightarrow H^1(X; \mathbb{Z}_2)$$

and

$$c_1: \text{Vect}_{\mathbb{C}}(X) \rightarrow H^2(X; \mathbb{Z})$$

are bijections.

This allows us to define line bundles by only prescribing their first Stiefel-Whitney class (resp. Chern class), which is often technically easier than directly writing down this bundle. While the first Stiefel-Whitney class of higher dimensional bundles does not identify their isomorphism type it does characterize another important invariant, namely orientability:

Proposition 1.18 (Hatcher, Prop 3.11). *Let X be a CW-complex. A real vector bundle $E \rightarrow X$ is orientable if and only if $w_1(E) = 0$.*

Similarly vanishing of the second Stiefel Whitney class $w_2(E)$ corresponds to the existence of another structure on E , namely a spin structure. We need not be concerned with what precisely a spin structure is, such that the following definition suffices for our purposes.

Definition 1.19. An orientable manifold M is called

- i) *spin*, if $w_2(TM) = 0$,
- ii) *totally non-spin*, if the universal cover of M is not spin.

Recall that a manifold M is orientable if and only if its tangent bundle TM restricted to any embedded loop $S^1 \subseteq M$ is trivial. Or in other words “ TM does not contain any Moebius Bands”. A similar characterization can be given for spin manifolds, which is why the property of being spin is sometimes referred to as a higher dimensional analogue of orientability.

Proposition 1.20 (Georg Paper, Proposition 2.6). *Let M be a connected oriented manifold of dimension at least 5.*

- i) *M is spin if and only if for every embedded surface $S \subseteq M$ the restriction $TM|_S$ of the tangent bundle to S is trivial.*
- ii) *M is totally non-spin if and only if there exists an embedded sphere $S^2 \subseteq M$, such that the restriction $TM|_{S^2}$ of the tangent bundle to this sphere is trivial.*

Proof. Since we will not be making use of the first characterization of spin manifolds, we shall only proof part ii) of the proposition and refer the reader to [Georg Paper] for a proof of part i).
...(Proof) □

Finally we record another scenario in which the vanishing of all Stiefel-Whitney classes of a bundle is sufficient for triviality.

Lemma 1.21. *Let $E \rightarrow S$ be a real vector bundle over a surface S of rank at least 3. Then E is trivial if and only if $w_1(E) = w_2(E) = 0$.*

proof...

2 Positive Scalar Curvature

2.1 Overview

brief definition, maybe intuition and obstructions/background etc. based on overview paper

psc is somehow sweet spot for rigidity and flexibility

Probably the most important existence Theorem for positive scalar curvature metrics... Before stating the theorem let us briefly recall what surgery theory is about. The basic observation is that a product $S^k \times S^{n-k-1}$ of spheres can be considered as the boundary of $S^k \times D^{n-k}$ or of $D^{k+1} \times S^{n-k-1}$... davor noch sowas schreiben wie "change the topology of a manifold in a controlled way"; remove thickened embedded k -sphere ($\rightarrow$ terminology of surgery of dimension k); EMBEDDINGS ALWAYS INTO INTERIOR (dann muss ich das unten in proposition zur surgery nicht mehr immer dazu schreiben) + can extend embedding of sphere iff trivial normal bundle; surgery intimately connected to cobordism theory; how does surgery correspond to handles?; one common application of surgery theory is to "kill" certain homotopy groups $\rightarrow$ explain this process more precisely below

Theorem 2.1 (Gromov, Lawson, 1980). (*Surgery Theorem*)

In order to apply this theorem we need a way to control the dimension of the surgeries performed or equivalently the indices of handles in a given cobordism. This question is completely independent of scalar curvature and has been subject of research especially in the context of the h -cobordism theorem. One central tool to control the indices of the handles in a cobordism is the following theorem due to Wall

Theorem 2.2 (Wall, 1971). (*Wall Theorem*)

Combining Gromov, Lawson and Wall we see that: M_0 is psc, $M_1 \rightarrow W$ 2-connected then M_1 psc. In fact one can use the Theorem of Wall to obtain an even stronger result:

Theorem 2.3 (extending psc to cobordism, Georg, Gaja). ...

So in view of the above discussion, the strategy to construct a psc metric on a given closed manifold M_1 of dimension at least 5 is to first find a cobordism W from some psc manifold M_0 to M_1 and then modify this cobordism by surgeries to obtain another cobordism W' from M_0 to M_1 , such that the inclusion $M_1 \rightarrow W'$ is 2-connected. Of course, such a modification by surgeries may not always be possible, so our next goal is to explain certain scenarios in which it is. In order to formulate these we recall the following definition.

Definition 2.4 (Spin and Totally non spin). ...

We now have the following two existence theorems for psc metrics. One for the spin case and one for the totally non-spin case.

Theorem 2.5. *Let W^{n+1} be a cobordism from M_0 to M_1 , $n \geq 5$, such that W is spin. Suppose that M_1 is connected, the inclusion $M_1 \rightarrow W$ induces an isomorphism on π_1 and that M_0 carries a psc-metric. Then M_1 also carries a psc-metric. In fact the psc-metric on M_0 can be extended to a psc-metric on W , which is of product form near the boundary.*

Theorem 2.6. *Let W^{n+1} be an oriented cobordism from M_0 to M_1 , $n \geq 5$. Suppose that M_1 is a connected totally non-spin manifold, the inclusion $M_1 \rightarrow W$ induces an isomorphism on π_1 and that M_0 carries a psc-metric. Then M_1 also carries a psc-metric. In fact the psc-metric on M_0 can be extended to a psc-metric on W , which is of product form near the boundary.*

By the general strategy we laid out above, the proofs of these theorems will be using the given data to perform surgery on the cobordism W , such that the inclusion $\iota: M_1 \rightarrow W$ becomes 2-connected. By assumption M_1 is connected and ι already induces an isomorphism on π_1 , so formulated differently our goal is to "kill" all generators in $\pi_2(W, M)$ by surgery. So as a first step let us make precise how one can use surgery to "kill" certain homotopy classes.

Proposition 2.7. *Let W^n be smooth manifold with basepoint $w_0 \in W$, $M \subseteq \partial W$ a boundary component with basepoint $x_0 \in M$ and $2(k+1) \leq n$.*

- i) Suppose we are given classes $\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_l \in \pi_k(W, w_0)$, which are represented by embeddings with trivial normal bundle. Then there exists a manifold W' obtained from W by l -many k -surgeries away from the point w_0 together with an epimorphism*

$$\pi_k(W, w_0) \twoheadrightarrow \pi_k(W', w_0)$$

containing the $\mathbb{Z}[\pi_1(W, w_0)]$ -module generated by $\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_l$ in its kernel. Moreover

$$\pi_i(W, w_0) \cong \pi_i(W', w_0)$$

for all $i \leq k-1$.

- ii) Suppose we are given classes $\alpha_1^{\text{rel}}, \dots, \alpha_l^{\text{rel}} \in \pi_k(W, M, x_0)$, which lift to classes $\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_l \in \pi_k(W, x_0)$ under the map $\pi_k(W, x_0) \rightarrow \pi_k(W, M, x_0)$ induced by the inclusion. Again assume that $\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_l$ are represented by embeddings with trivial normal bundle. Then there exists a manifold W' obtained from W by l -many k -surgeries together with an epimorphism*

$$\pi_k(W, M, x_0) \twoheadrightarrow \pi_k(W', M, x_0)$$

containing the $\mathbb{Z}[\pi_1(M, x_0)]$ -module generated by $\alpha_1^{\text{rel}}, \dots, \alpha_l^{\text{rel}}$ in its kernel. Moreover

$$\pi_i(W, M, x_0) \cong \pi_i(W', M, x_0)$$

for all $i \leq k-1$.

Proof of proposition 2.7

Proof of Theorem 2.6 and 2.5

In the main construction in section ... we will invoke Theorem 2.6 to construct a psc metric, so let us conclude this section by discussing some basic results for identifying totally non-spin manifolds.

Lemma 2.8. *(i) The product of a totally non-spin manifold with any non-empty manifold is totally non-spin.*

(ii) A manifold containing a totally non-spin submanifold of codimension 0 is totally non-spin.

(iii) If M is totally non-spin and of dimension $n \geq 3$, then $M - D^n$ is totally non-spin for any embedded disk $D^n \subseteq \text{int}(M)$ in the interior of M .

Remark 2.9. All statements of the above lemma remain valid if “totally non-spin” is replaced by “non-spin”. The corresponding proofs are just simpler versions of the arguments given below.

Proof. For (i) let M_1 and M_2 be manifolds with M_1 totally non-spin. Then the universal cover of the product $M_1 \times M_2$ is given by the product $\tilde{M}_1 \times \tilde{M}_2$ of the respective universal covers. Denote by

$$\pi_1: \tilde{M}_1 \times \tilde{M}_2 \rightarrow \tilde{M}_1, \quad \pi_2: \tilde{M}_1 \times \tilde{M}_2 \rightarrow \tilde{M}_2$$

the projections and let $\iota: \tilde{M}_1 \rightarrow \tilde{M}_1 \times \tilde{M}_2$ be an inclusion for some choice of basepoint in $\tilde{M}_2$. We compute

$$\begin{aligned} \iota^* w_2(T(\tilde{M}_1 \times \tilde{M}_2)) &= \iota^* w_2(\pi_1^* T\tilde{M}_1 \oplus \pi_2^* T\tilde{M}_2) \\ &= w_2((\pi_1 \circ \iota)^* T\tilde{M}_1 \oplus (\pi_2 \circ \iota)^* T\tilde{M}_2) \\ &= w_2(T\tilde{M}_1) \neq 0, \end{aligned}$$

where we used that $\pi_1 \circ \iota$ is the identity and that $\pi_2 \circ \iota$ is constant, such that $(\pi_2 \circ \iota)^* T\tilde{M}_2$ is trivial. Thus $w_2(T(\tilde{M}_1 \times \tilde{M}_2)) \neq 0$.

For (ii) suppose that $N \subseteq M$ is some totally non-spin codimension 0 submanifold of the manifold M . Let $\iota: N \rightarrow M$ be the inclusion and consider its lift to the universal covers:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} \tilde{N} & \xrightarrow{\tilde{\iota}} & \tilde{M} \\ \downarrow & & \downarrow \\ N & \xrightarrow{\iota} & M \end{array}$$

Since $\tilde{\iota}$ is a local diffeomorphism, the differential $d\tilde{\iota}: T\tilde{N} \rightarrow T\tilde{M}$ is a fiber-wise isomorphism, such that the following is a pullback diagram

$$\begin{array}{ccc} T\tilde{N} & \xrightarrow{d\tilde{\iota}} & T\tilde{M} \\ \downarrow & & \downarrow \\ \tilde{N} & \xrightarrow{\tilde{\iota}} & \tilde{M} \end{array}$$

Therefore $\tilde{\iota}^*w_2(T\tilde{M}) = w_2(T\tilde{N}) \neq 0$ and so $w_2(T\tilde{M}) \neq 0$.

For (iii) assume without loss generality that M is connected. Denote by $B^n := \text{int}(D^n)$ the open ball. Then $M - D^n$ is the interior of $M - B^n$ from which we conclude that $M - D^n$ is totally non-spin if and only if $M - B^n$ is totally non-spin. This follows using an analogous argument as in (ii) by noting that for a manifold X with boundary the universal cover of $\text{int}(X)$ is given by $\text{int}(\tilde{X})$ and the inclusion $\text{int}(\tilde{X}) \rightarrow \tilde{X}$ is a homotopy equivalence. We will now show that $M - B^n$ is totally non-spin. Let $p: \tilde{M} \rightarrow M$ be the universal cover of M and write $M_0 := M - B^n$. We claim that the universal cover of M_0 agrees with the covering

$$\hat{M}_0 = \tilde{M}|_{M_0} = \tilde{M} - p^{-1}(B^n) \xrightarrow{p} M_0.$$

First of all $\hat{M}_0$ is connected as $n \geq 2$. We now have to show that $\hat{M}_0$ is simply connected. Let $F = p^{-1}(x)$ be some fiber of p . From the classification of coverings we see that

$$p^{-1}(B^n) \cong B^n \times F$$

since B^n is simply connected. If the fiber F is finite we can apply the Seifert-van-Kampen Theorem to conclude that $\tilde{M}$ with a single disk B^n removed is still simply connected, such that the statement follows inductively. If the fiber is not finite we can argue more generally as follows. Let $\phi: S^1 \rightarrow \hat{M}_0$ be some smooth loop. Certainly we can contract this loop in $\tilde{M}$, that is we can find some map $\Phi: D^2 \rightarrow \tilde{M}$ restricting to α on the boundary. We now show that Φ is homotopic rel S^1 to some map $\Phi_1: D^2 \rightarrow \tilde{M}$, such that the image of Φ_1 is already contained in $\hat{M}_0$, from which the claim follows. To construct such a homotopy let $0 \in B^n \subseteq M$ be the center of the embedded disk. After a preliminary homotopy we may assume that Φ is transversal to $p^{-1}(0)$. The crucial observation is that, since $n \geq 3$, this is equivalent to requiring that Φ does not intersect $p^{-1}(0)$. Now note that S^{n-1} is a strong deformation retract of $D^n - 0$ and applying such a deformation retraction on each disk $D^n - 0 \subseteq p^{-1}(D^n - 0)$ shows that $\hat{M}_0$ is a strong deformation retract of $\tilde{M} - p^{-1}(0)$. Let

$$r: \tilde{M} - p^{-1}(0) \rightarrow \hat{M}_0$$

be such a retraction and let

$$r_t: \tilde{M} - p^{-1}(0) \rightarrow \tilde{M} - p^{-1}(0)$$

be a homotopy rel S^1 from the identity to r (composed with the corresponding inclusion). Then $\Phi_t := r_t \circ \Phi$ defines a homotopy rel S^1 from Φ to some map Φ_1 whose image is contained in $\hat{M}_0$. This shows the claim and hence the universal cover of M_0 is given by

$$\hat{M}_0 = \tilde{M} - p^{-1}(B^n) \cong \tilde{M} - (B^n \times F).$$

Finally, the Mayer-Vietoris sequence of the pushout

$$\begin{array}{ccc} S^{n-1} \times F & \longrightarrow & D^n \times F \\ \downarrow & & \downarrow \\ \tilde{M} - (B^n \times F) & \xrightarrow{\iota} & \tilde{M} \end{array}$$

where all maps are inclusions, then shows that ι is injective on $H^2(-; \mathbb{Z}_2)$. Therefore

$$w_2(T\hat{M}_0) = w_2(\iota^*T\tilde{M}) = \iota^*w_2(T\tilde{M}) \neq 0.$$

□

A standard example of a non-spin manifold is $\mathbb{C}P^2$. Since $\mathbb{C}P^2$ is simply connected this is also an example of a totally non-spin manifold, which we will appeal to in section ...

Lemma 2.10. $\mathbb{C}P^2$ is non-spin.

(proof)